(U) Enemy Forces

(U) Strategy

(S//REL TO USA, MCFI) The insurgent strategy to defend Fallujah was designed to accomplish two things: 1) to gain media attention and sympathy and 2) to inflict maximum Coalition casualties by forcing a close-quarters infantry fight in urban terrain. Those cells that remained in Fallujah to fight were intent on dragging the combat out as long as possible to enable political and IO pressure to build to a boiling point.

(U) Operational Plan

(S//REL TO USA, MCFI) The Fallujah insurgents could count on cooperation and support from other networks in the surrounding towns of Saqlawiyah, Ar Ramadi, Amariyah, and Karmah. As a result, VIGILANT RESOLVE stirred up a hornet's nest across the Al Anbar Province, especially in Ar Ramadi, as insurgent cells surged their activity to stretch Coalition forces thin during the operation. They emplaced numerous roadblocks, IEDs, and complex ambushes on the key lines of communication (LOCs) in the area to interdict Coalition supply convoys and patrols. MSRs Mobile and Michigan were especially targeted. Insurgents attempted to damage and destroy key bridges, such as the one crossing the Thar Thar Canal.

(S//REL TO USA, MCFI) Throughout the fight insurgents demonstrated operational freedom of movement. Fighters and supplies were infiltrated through the Marine cordon and into Fallujah in various ways:

• (U) Insurgent local knowledge facilitated using a variety of back roads and hidden trails not blocked by entry control points (ECPs).

• (U) Some contraband was smuggled through Marine checkpoints by "civilians."

• (U) It is likely that Iraqi police voluntarily collaborated or were bribed.